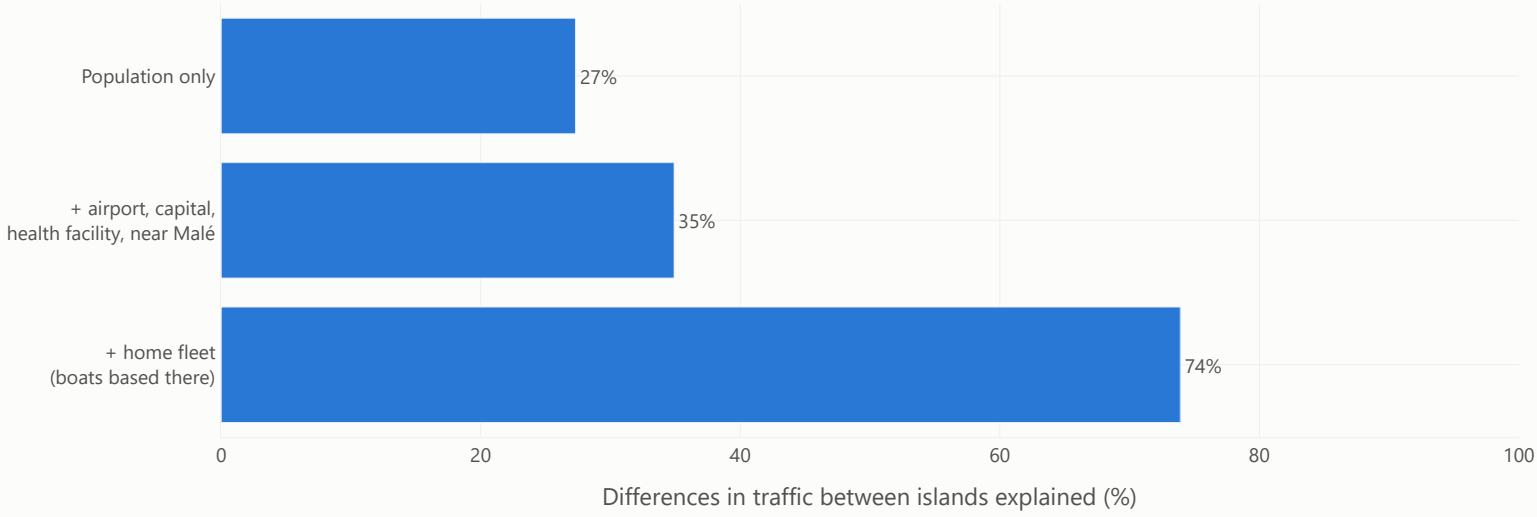
Does each island need a bigger jetty?

Vessel traffic (FollowMe trackers, August 2025) compared with population (Census 2022), airports, atoll capitals, health facilities and each island's home fleet. Hover over any dot or bar for details, drag to zoom, double-click to reset.

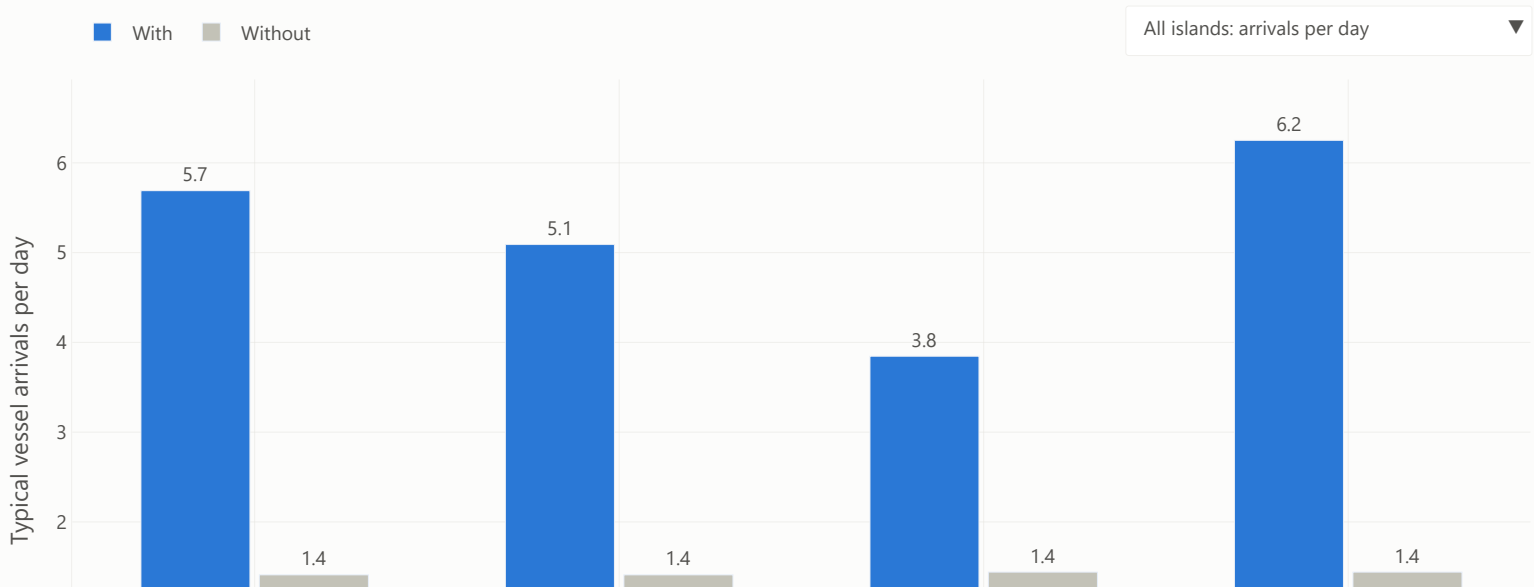
- Bigger islands do get more boats, but less than proportionally: rank correlation 0.56 for arrivals and 0.58 for distinct vessels. Doubling the population goes with about 1.66x the arrivals.
- Population alone explains 27% of the differences in traffic between islands; adding airport, capital, hospital and location raises that to 35%.
- Holding the rest equal, an airport goes with +1% arrivals (not statistically clear).
- Holding the rest equal, being the atoll capital goes with -1% arrivals (not statistically clear).
- Holding the rest equal, being in Kaafu, near Malé goes with +10% arrivals (not statistically clear).
- Each step up in hospital level (health centre → atoll → regional → tertiary) goes with +14% arrivals.
- Adding each island's home fleet (boats that spend most nights there, mostly fishing and work vessels) raises the explained share to 74%. Islands with twice the home fleet see 103% more traffic.
- Verdicts: Weak case 48, Moderate 39, Check access 33, Strong case, local fleet 26, No data 14, Strong case 11, Strong case, wider role 9, Moderate, growing role 6, Airport transfer point 4, National hub 2.

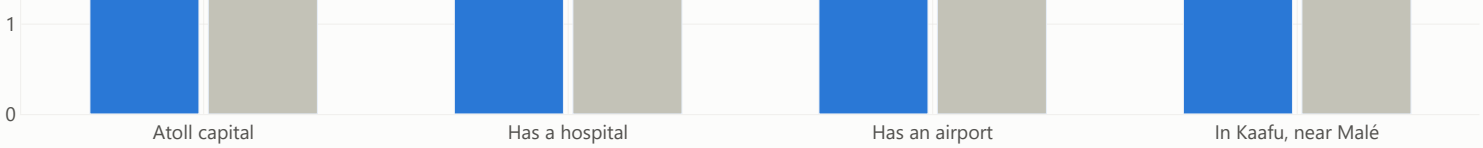
The island's own boats explain traffic far better than population



Each bar shows how much of the difference in boat traffic between islands can be explained by a set of factors, from 0% (no help at all) to 100% (predicts traffic perfectly). The first bar uses only how many people live on the island. The second adds whether it has an airport, is the atoll capital, its health facility level and whether it is near Malé. The last adds its home fleet: the boats that spend most nights there. The longer the bar, the better those factors explain how busy an island's jetty is. Here: Population only 27%, airport, capital, health facility, near Malé 35%, home fleet (boats based there) 74%.

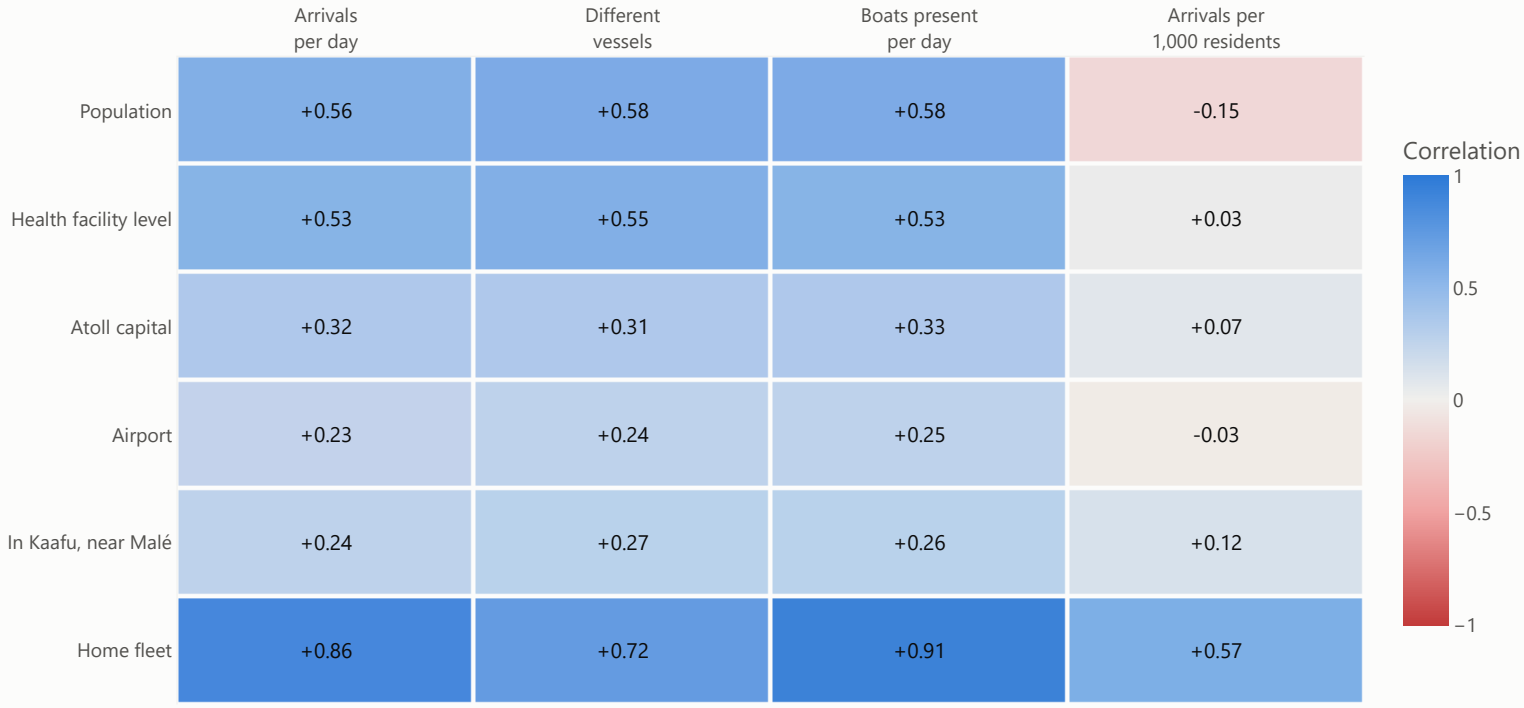
Do capitals, hospitals and airports get more traffic?





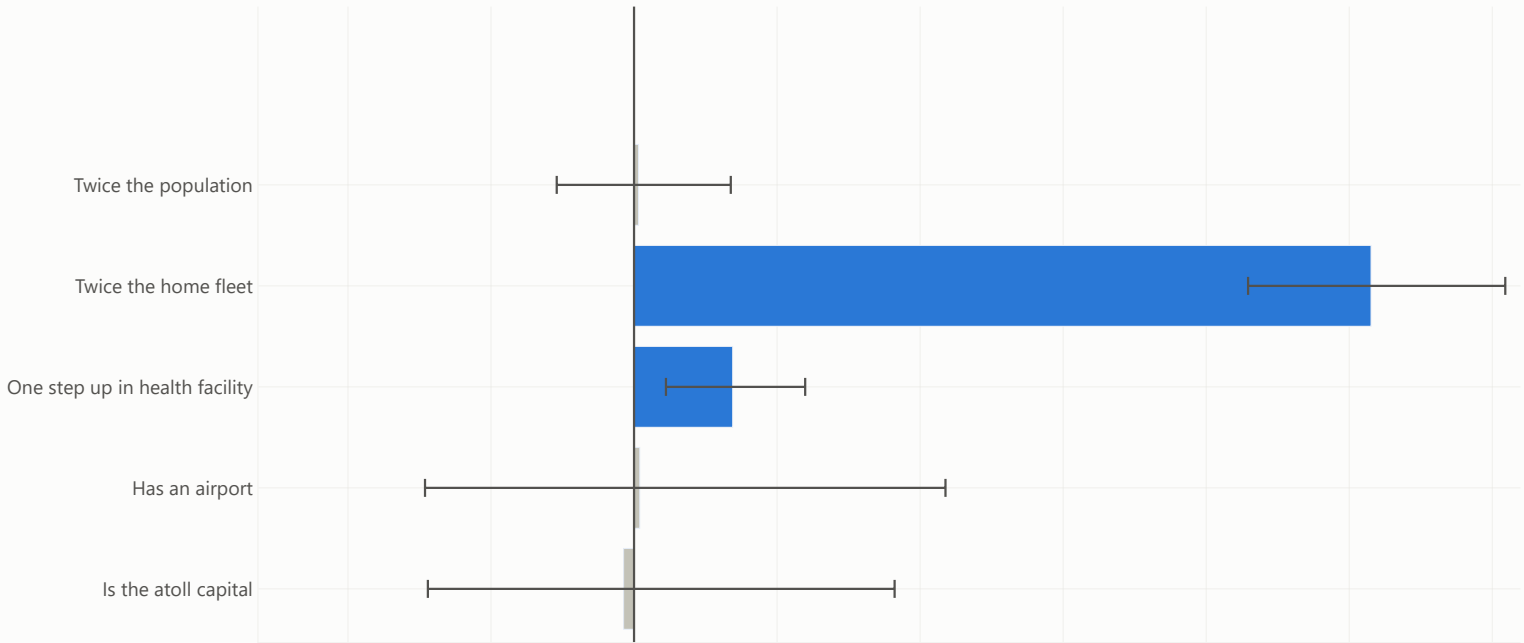
For each factor, the blue bar is the typical (median) island that has it and the grey bar the typical island that does not. On all islands, capitals, hospital islands, airport islands and Kaafu islands are all far busier, but they are also much bigger, so part of the gap is just population. Use the dropdown above the chart to compare only islands of similar size (1,500 to 5,000 people), or to compare traffic per 1,000 residents. A gap that survives those views is a real pull of that factor; a gap that disappears was mostly island size. Hover over a bar for how many islands are in each group and their typical population.

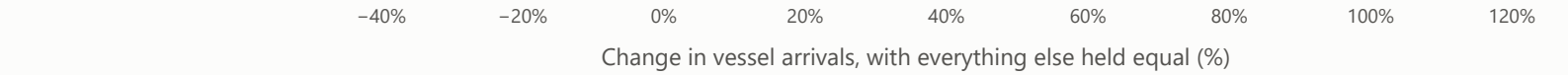
How traffic correlates with island features



How strongly each island feature moves together with each measure of traffic, from -1 (always opposite) through 0 (no link) to +1 (always together). Blue cells are positive links, red cells negative, pale cells none. Population and health facility level have the strongest links with how many boats arrive, how many different vessels come and how many are present, but these two also go together (big islands have the hospitals), so read them alongside the "everything else held equal" chart. The last column, traffic per 1,000 residents, is close to zero for most features: per person, capitals and hospital islands are not much busier, their extra traffic largely comes with their larger size and the visitors their services draw.

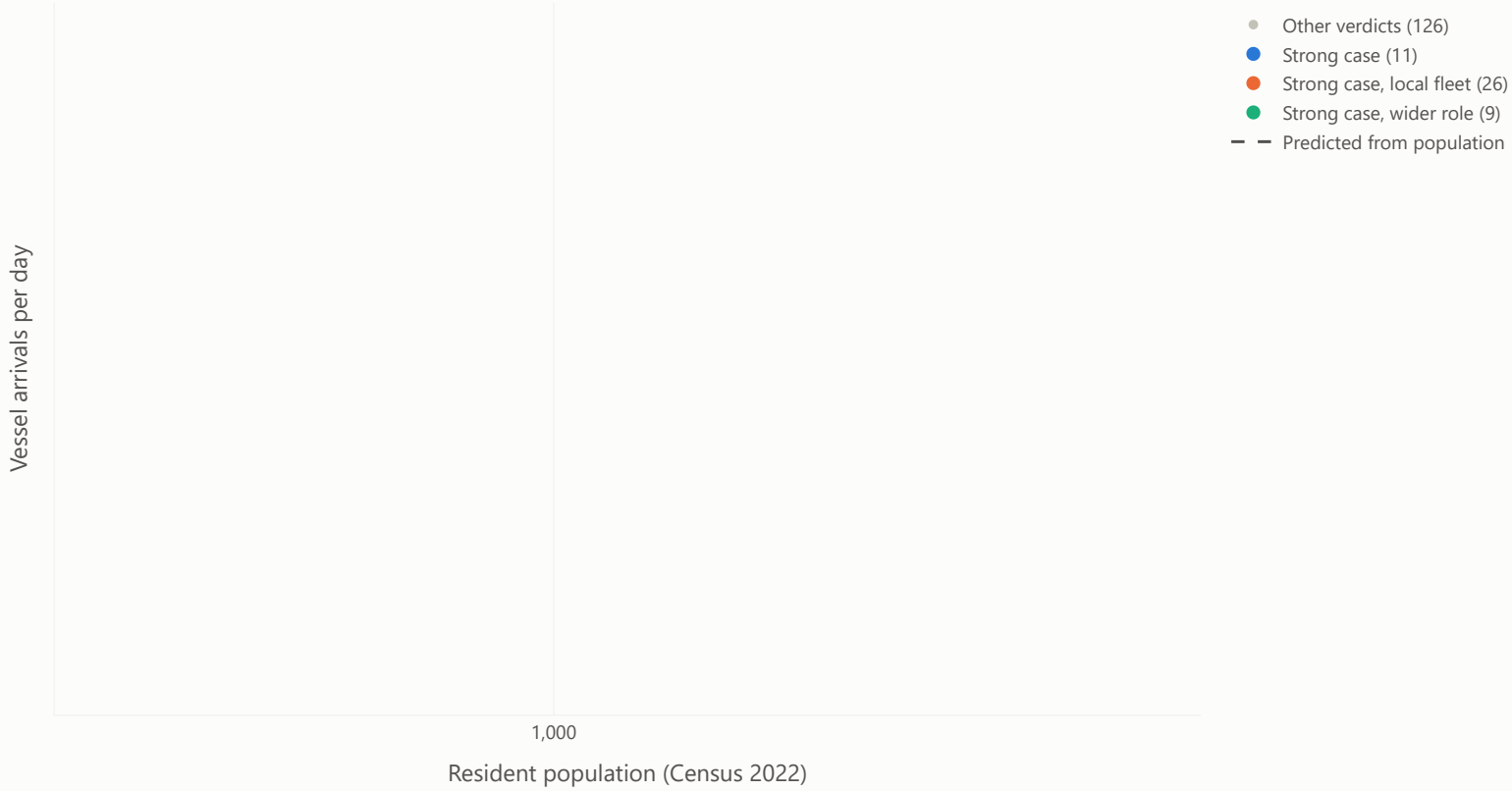
What raises traffic, with everything else held equal





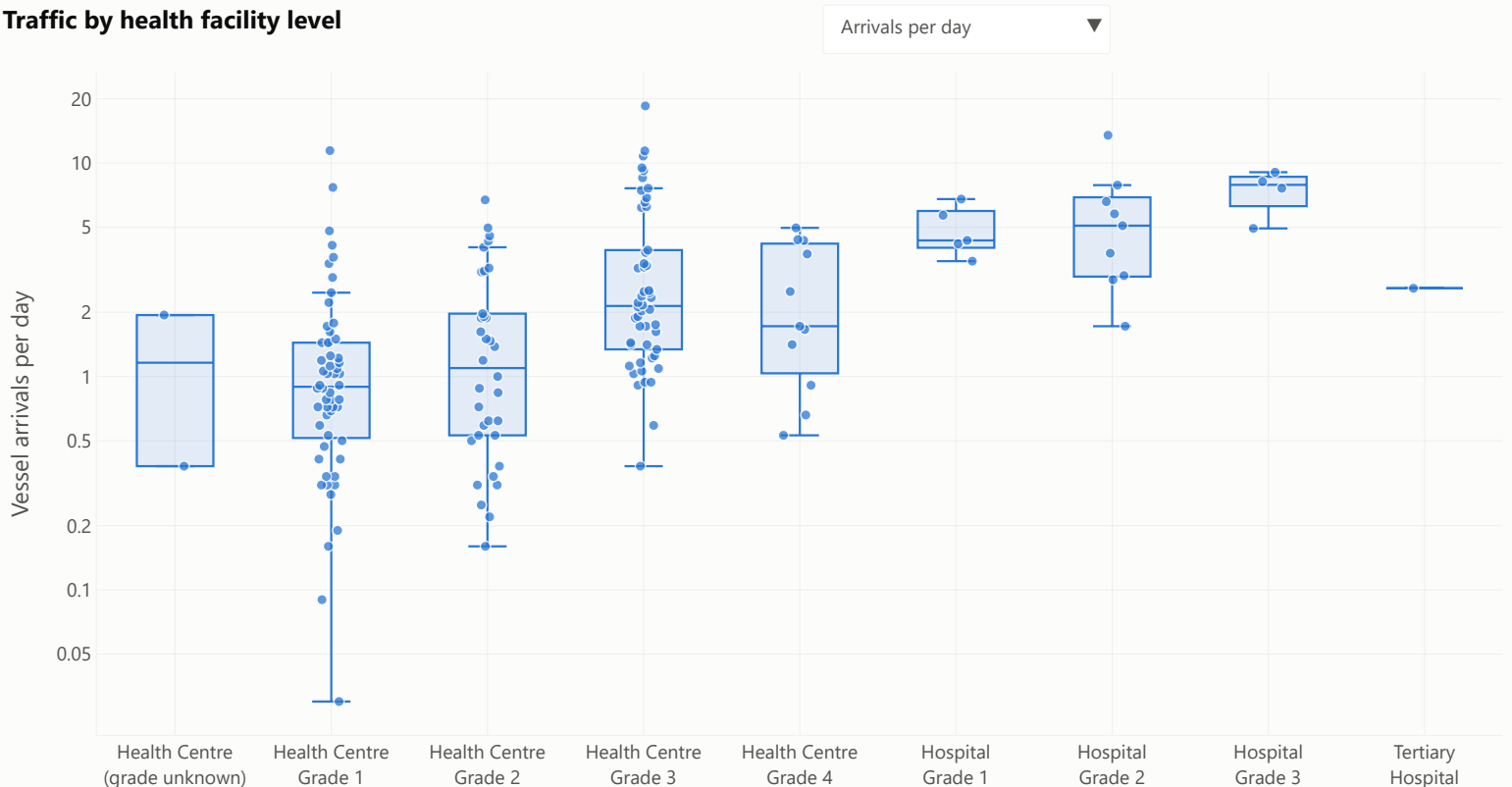
Each bar is the separate effect of one factor on an island's vessel traffic, after accounting for all the others at once. This matters because hospitals, airports and capitals tend to be on the biggest islands: comparing them directly would mix up the effect of the hospital with the effect of having more people. Blue bars are statistically clear; grey bars could be chance. The thin line on each bar is the likely range: if it crosses 0%, the data cannot rule out no effect at all. Hover over a bar for the exact numbers.

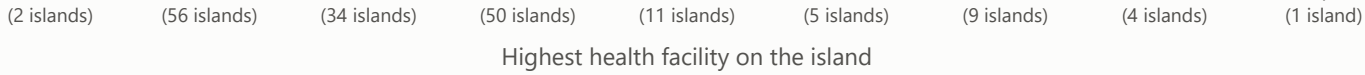
Bigger islands get more boats, but loosely (rank correlation 0.56)



Each dot is one inhabited island. Further right means more residents (Census 2022); higher means more vessel arrivals per day (August 2025). Both axes are on a log scale, so each step is ten times the one before. The dashed line is the traffic an island would get from its population alone. Dots above the line are busier than their population suggests (tourism, services or a large local fleet); dots below are quieter than expected. Coloured dots are islands with a strong case for a bigger jetty. The rank correlation of 0.56 (0 = no link, 1 = perfect) shows population matters, but is far from the whole story.

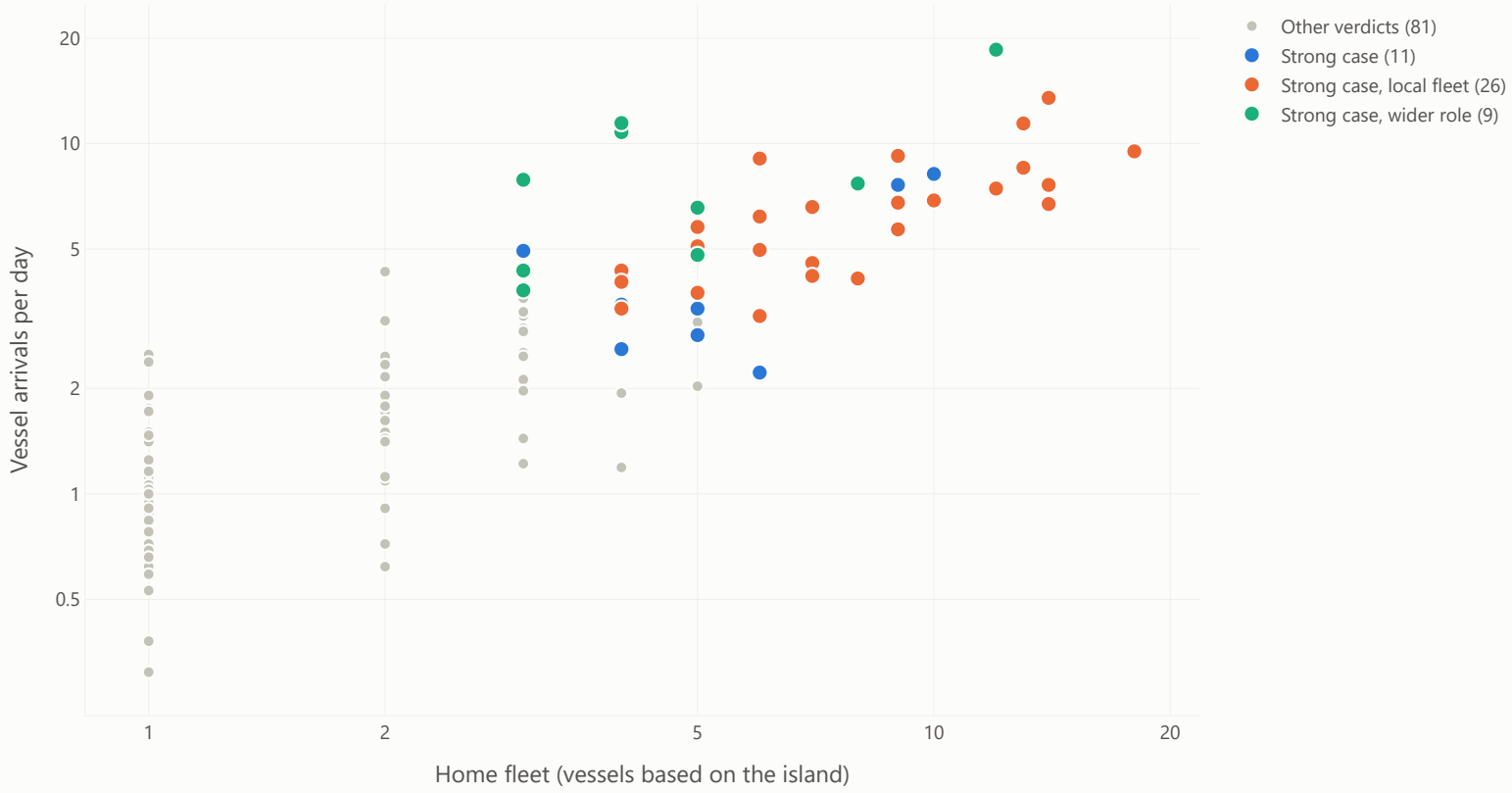
Traffic by health facility level





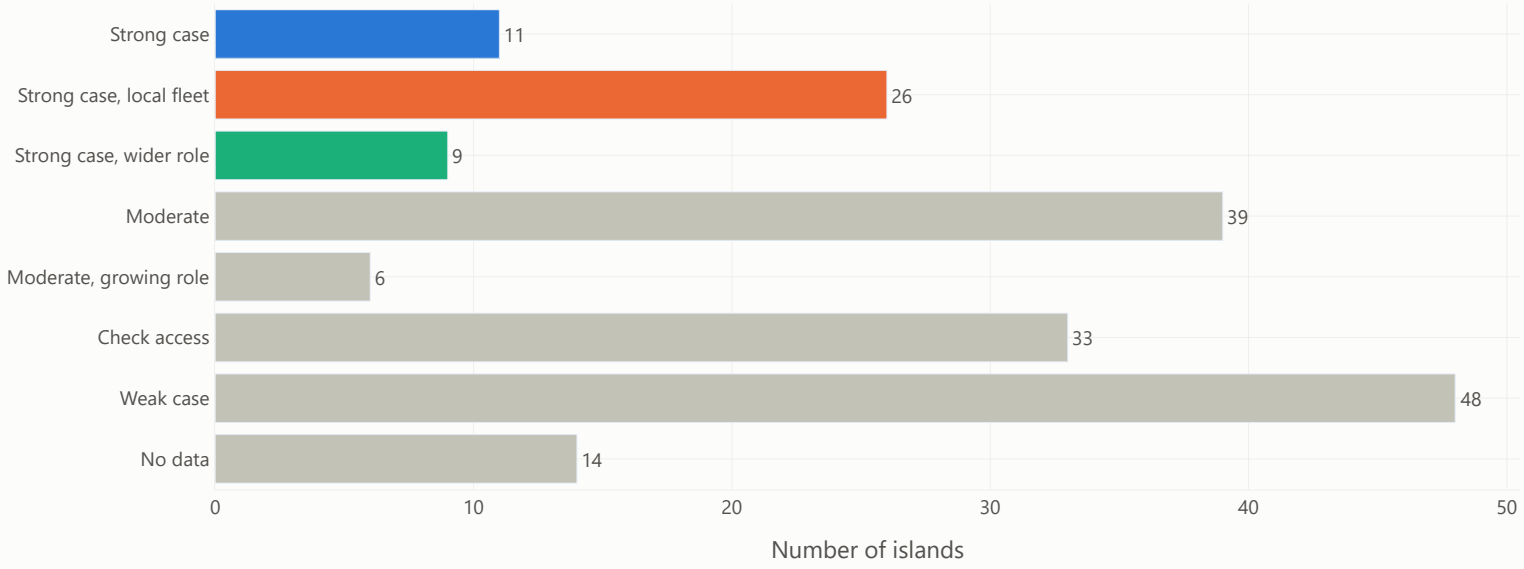
Each dot is one island, grouped by the highest health facility it has, from the smallest health centre on the left to the tertiary hospital on the right. The box shows where the middle half of those islands sit and the line inside it is the typical island. Boxes that climb from left to right mean better-equipped islands get more boats: people from neighbouring islands travel there for treatment and services. Use the dropdown above the chart to switch to arrivals per 1,000 residents, which removes the effect of island size. Islands with hospitals are also the biggest, so see the "everything else held equal" chart for the hospital effect on its own. Hover over a dot for the island.

Islands with more of their own boats see much more traffic



Each dot is one island, placed by its home fleet (vessels that spend most nights there: fishing, ferry, guesthouse and work boats) against its vessel arrivals per day. Both axes are on a log scale. The dots rise together much more tightly than in the population chart: islands with more boats of their own generate more jetty traffic. That demand comes from residents' livelihoods, which is the strongest argument that citizens themselves justify a bigger jetty.

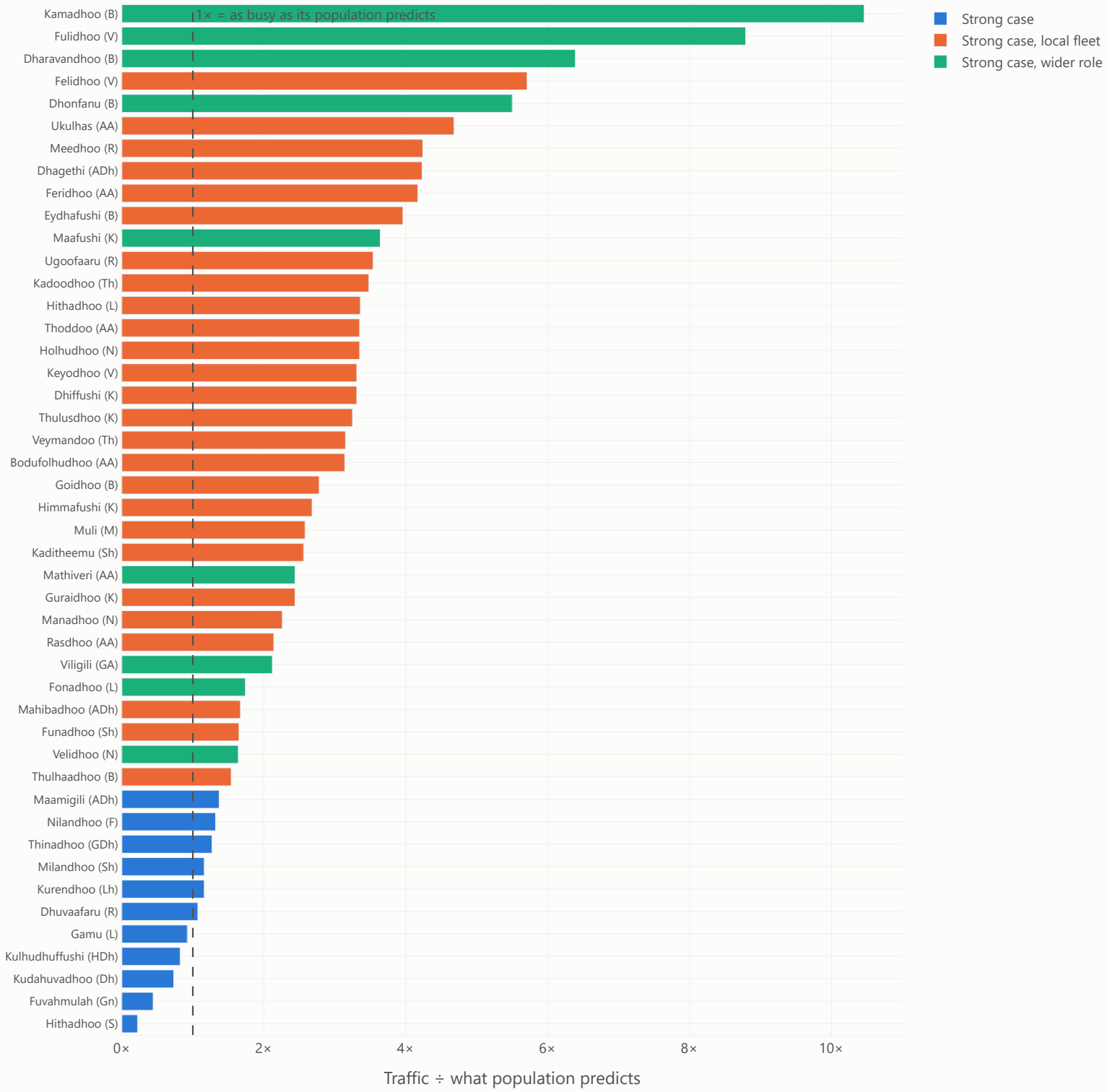
Jetty verdicts across inhabited islands



How many inhabited islands fall into each verdict; hover over a bar for example islands. Strong case: very busy, in line with its population. Strong case, local fleet: very busy because of the boats based on the island. Strong case, wider role: busier than population and fleet explain, likely tourism or transit, so the case is economic. Moderate: fairly busy, a medium priority. Check

access: much less traffic than its population predicts, worth a site visit. Weak case: low traffic for its size. No data: the island was not found on the map.

Strong cases: how far traffic goes beyond the resident population



Every island with a strong case for a bigger jetty, ranked by its actual traffic divided by the traffic its population alone would predict. The dashed line at 1× means exactly as busy as its population suggests; 3× means three times busier. Short blue bars are justified by residents alone. Orange bars go beyond population but are explained by the island's own fleet and services. Long green bars are driven by something else, mostly tourism, transfers or transit. Click a colour in the legend to show or hide that group.